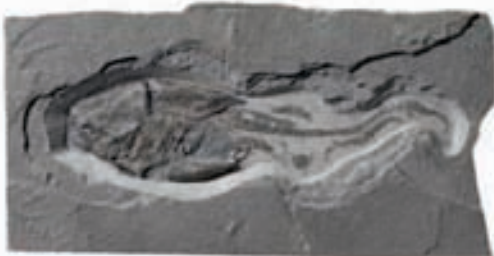


Coccosteus

cock-oh-STEE-us

- **When** 380–350 million years ago (Middle to Late Devonian)
- **Fossil location** N. America, Europe
- **Habitat** Shallow waters
- **Length** 16 in (40 cm)



Although quite small in size, *Coccosteus* was an effective predator. It hunted other fish, perhaps lying in wait on the seabed for its prey before ambushing. Like *Dunkleosteus*, it had a beaklike mouth, with sharp, bladelike edges to tear flesh off larger animals. Its fossils show that it had a powerful tail, suggesting that it was a strong swimmer.

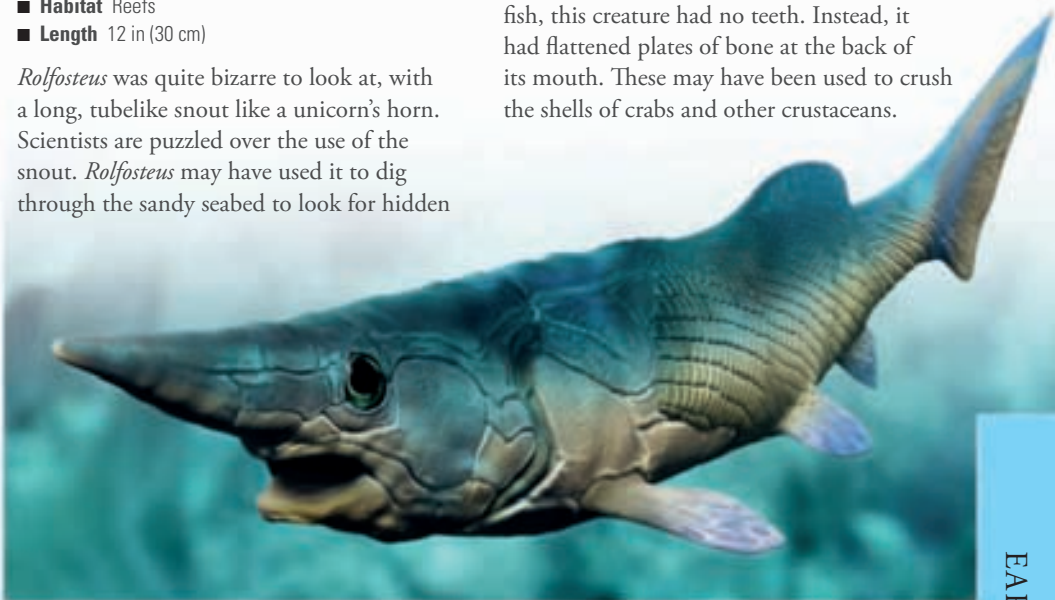
Rolfosteus

ROLL-foss-tee-us

- **When** 380 million years ago (Late Devonian)
- **Fossil location** Australia
- **Habitat** Reefs
- **Length** 12 in (30 cm)

Rolfosteus was quite bizarre to look at, with a long, tubelike snout like a unicorn's horn. Scientists are puzzled over the use of the snout. *Rolfosteus* may have used it to dig through the sandy seabed to look for hidden

prey, or it may have been a male ornament used to attract females. Like other armored fish, this creature had no teeth. Instead, it had flattened plates of bone at the back of its mouth. These may have been used to crush the shells of crabs and other crustaceans.



EARLY VERTEBRATES



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Armor-plated bodies
- Jaws with bony plates that served as teeth
- Joints between armor plates allowed the jaws to open and the body to bend

When

Armored fish lived from the Late Silurian Period, nearly 430 million years ago, to the end of the Devonian Period, 359 million years ago.